

ECIL Established 1967

From manufacturing EVMS that oil the nation's democratic wheels to the antenna system for Chandrayaan-1, ECIL, with a turnover of over Rs 1,000 crore, makes good business and good sense

SAFE AND SECURE

Prior to the Commonwealth Games, the Home Ministry is planning to spread a massive security cover over the Capital. With three key electronic systems, the ministry plans to carry out aerial imaging of the entire city and monitor all vehicles entering and exiting the its borders. The Government is zeroing in on Electronics Corporation of India Limited (ECIL), Hyderabad, to design equipment for this project. Not surprising given that from manufacturing electronic voting machines (EVMS) to instrumentation requirements of the nuclear power programme, the ECIL has been in the frontline of the nation's battle of wills and ideas. A wholly-owned government enterprise, it was established in 1967 to create a strong indigenous base in electronics.

The company had troubled early days during which it focused only on control and instrumentation of nuclear plants and electronic goods but in the late 1990s, it chose to diversify into high-end technology. With a human resource pool of over 4,800 engineers and technicians, its current turnover is over Rs 1,080 crore. The latest feather in ECIL's cap is the manufacture and commissioning of the 32m Deep Space Network (DSN) Antenna

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Y.S. Mayya 53, CMD

"ECIL is associated with many strategic programmes of the defence organisations in the area of communication systems for electronic warfare."

System for the Chandrayaan-1 Moon Mission. As the spacecraft entered the lunar orbit and continued its perambulations around the moon, the DSN antenna functioned as its eyes and ears day and night. In Somaliland, ECIL's the mobile voter enrolment system helped complete enumeration of the voters.

Back home, out of the total 1.36 million EVMS used in the 2009 Lok Sabha elections, ECIL manufactured and supplied 7.5 lakh EVMS. About doubts being raised on the efficiency of the EVMS, Y.S. Mayya, 53, chairman and managing

director, ECIL, says, "EVMS developed by ECIL are tamperproof and tamper-indicating. Unlike those developed by western nations, ECIL's EVMS are stand-alone machines and not part of any network. They have embedded software systems with fused programmes and don't permit alteration of software code. They are rugged mechanically and electrically, robust against mistakes, abuse, misuse and are simple to use," he adds.

It has also developed Electronics Warfare and Surveillance Systems, an active radar seeker for the Prithvi missile and pilot-less tracking antenna for the defence forces. After all, in modern warfare, the side who wins the battle is the side whose last antenna is still intact. **by Shafi Rahman**